

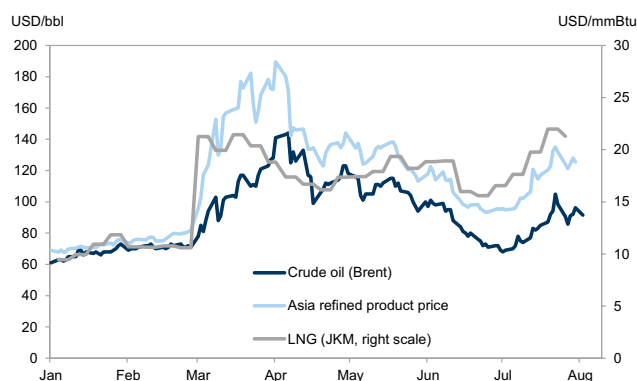
Asia Views: Macro mix still favors north Asia

1. Tech exports and energy imports continue to differentiate Asian economies.

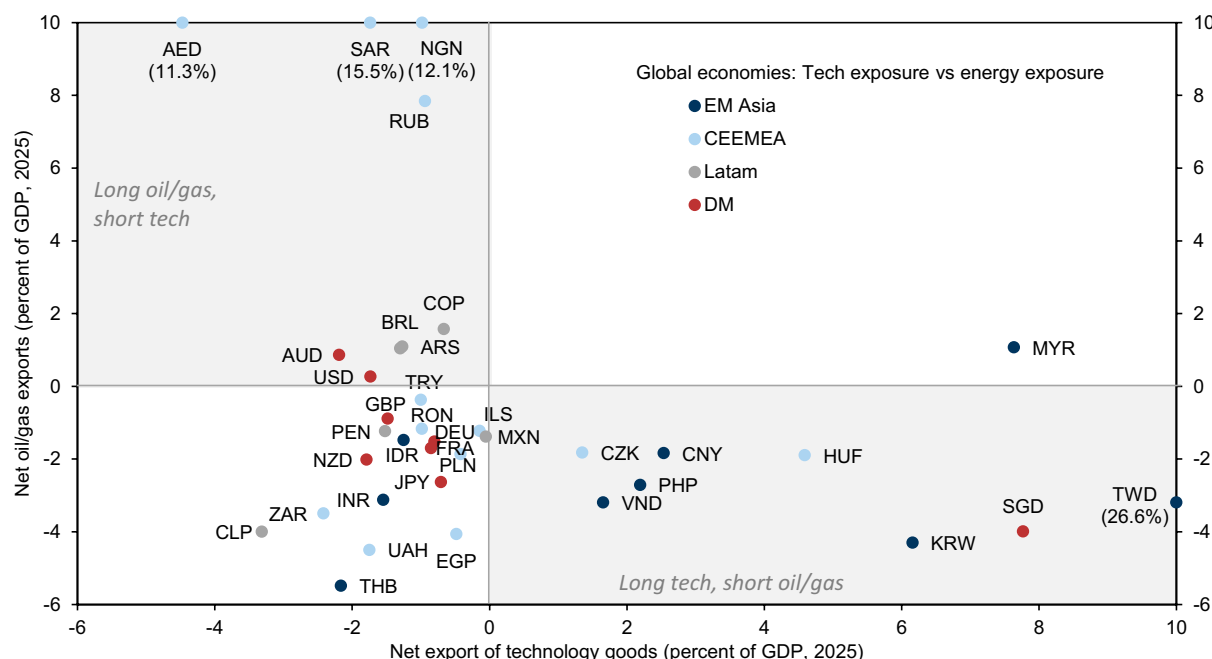
Surging AI investment is driving equipment spending, with Taiwan the biggest—but certainly not only—beneficiary. The tech export boom is driving enormous surpluses in north Asia and, to varying degrees, spilling over into stronger domestic activity. At the same time, renewed hostilities between the US and Iran have pushed energy prices back up (Exhibit 1). This is a headwind for Asian economies, especially those without significant exposure to AI-related demand and with limited local refining capacity. (Exhibit 2 provides a rough gauge of tech vs energy sensitivity: the horizontal axis relates to tech exposure, with economies to the right “long tech” in the sense of being net electronics exporters; the vertical axis relates to energy, with economies towards the bottom relatively more reliant on oil and gas imports; those in the bottom left quadrant are both “short energy” and “short tech”.)

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Exhibit 1: Renewed uptick in energy prices in July; refined product prices far above pre-war levels

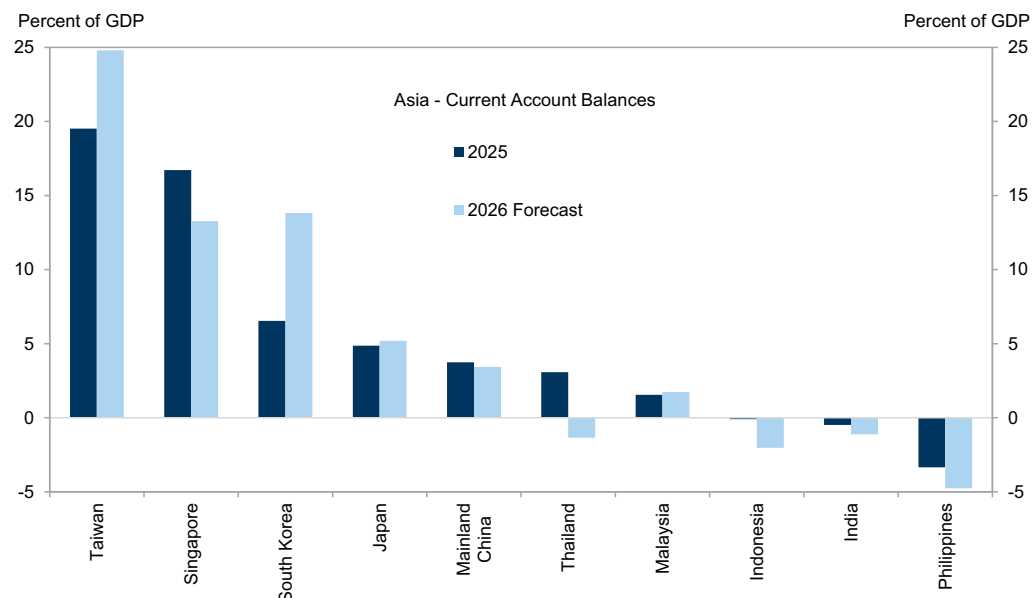


Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

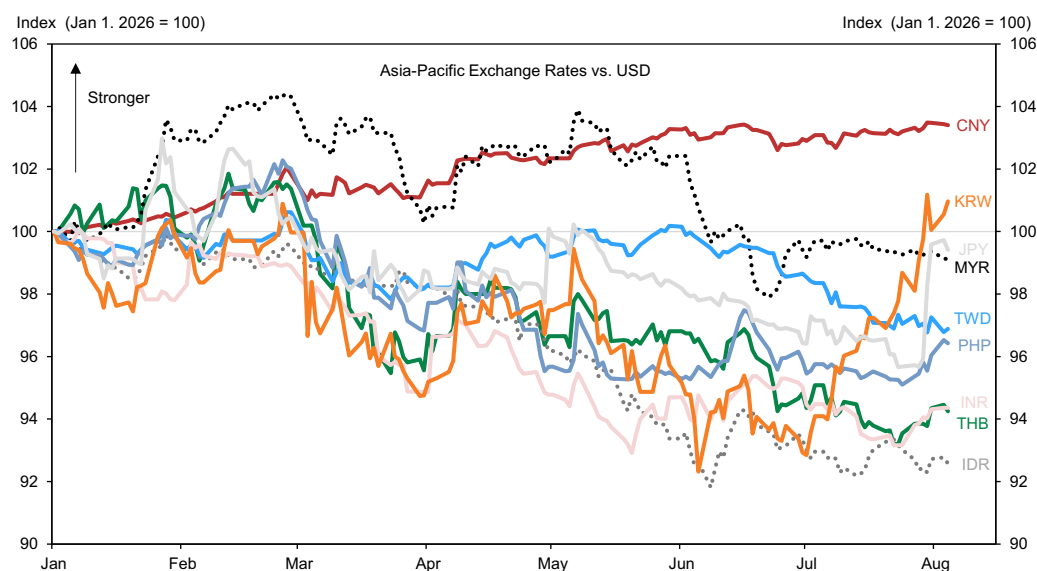
Exhibit 2: Asian economies have wide variation in tech exposure but are generally short energy

Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

2. “Super surpluses” are developing in the northeast Asian economies (Exhibit 3). In the case of Taiwan and Korea, these surpluses have been driven by the surge in exports of AI servers and their key semiconductor components. China’s surplus is much broader-based and has been turbocharged by heavy investment in emerging sectors, weak domestic demand, a push for “self-reliance”, and deepening FX undervaluation in recent years. The biggest counterpart to Asia’s surpluses is the trade deficit of the United States—more than \$1tn over the past year. There is a similarly stark gap in FX valuations, with Japan, Korea, Taiwan, and China the principal counterparts to the overvalued USD. While a competitive currency has often been an unstated policy goal, policymakers in Japan and Korea, and increasingly China, now appear to prefer modestly stronger currencies. In China’s case, continued gradual appreciation (Exhibit 4) could help reduce trade tensions as well as assisting in RMB internationalization. If market participants expect CNY strengthening, this could help attract foreign funds to low-yielding domestic fixed income assets—one objective of the policy push to establish the CNY as an alternative reserve currency (policymakers are also building out additional financial “plumbing” to the same end - e.g. the launch of CGB futures in Hong Kong this week). With inflation generally lower in China than elsewhere, and the USD overvalued, a slow grind lower in USDCNY would not be likely to impair China’s export competitiveness anytime soon.

Exhibit 3: “Super surpluses” in tech exporters / north Asia

Source: Global Investment Research

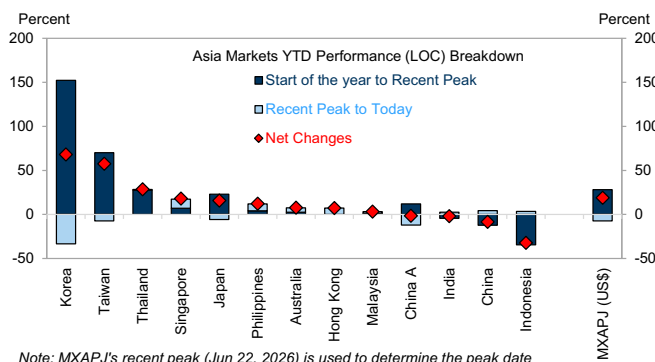
Exhibit 4: KRW rallied in July, but CNY remains the clear outperformer for 2026

Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

3. After an epic run over the past year, Korean equities sold off sharply over the past six weeks as a string of catalysts passed, the sustainability of high AI capex was questioned, new competition is on the horizon, and levered positions exacerbated moves (Exhibit 5). The Bank of Korea has also begun what we expect to be a modest tightening cycle (we expect two more rate hikes by early 2027). The Korean won has rebounded sharply (refer back to Exhibit 4) supported by ADR repatriation inflows and easing in foreign outflows—driven in part by foreign funds hitting country or single-name limits as Korean equities surged. Ironically, all this is happening just as signs of domestic spillovers are becoming visible. Investment is set to accelerate on the

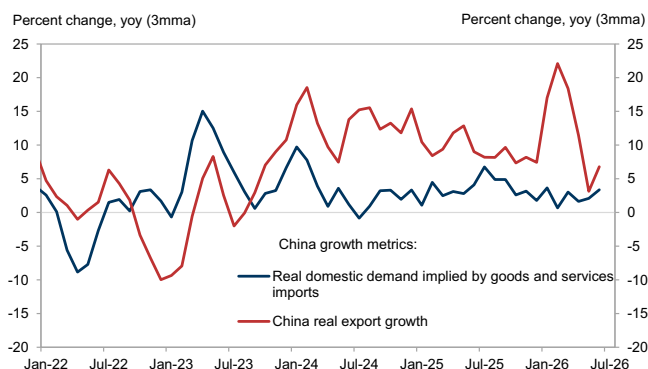
government's "3 Mega Projects" and memory producers' capacity expansions. Consumption has also accelerated slightly, although we think the effects here will be modest as the number of employees directly benefiting is small and wealth effects may be limited given high equity volatility and household debt. A tax windfall of over 5% of GDP will underpin a near-doubling in government spending growth to 10% next year, but also allow for a halving of the budget deficit. Domestic spillovers are already more evident in Taiwan, where the chip investment boom has been underway longer — capex growth is tracking in the high single digits and consumer spending at nearly a 5% pace.

Exhibit 5: Korea and Taiwan equities big outperformers this year, even after the recent selloff



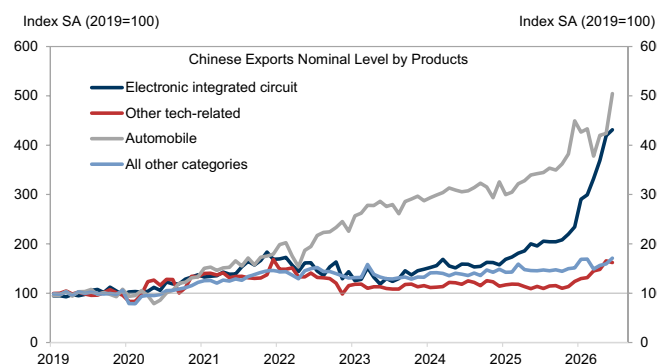
Source: FactSet, MSCI, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 6: China's exports have outperformed domestic demand for nearly three years running

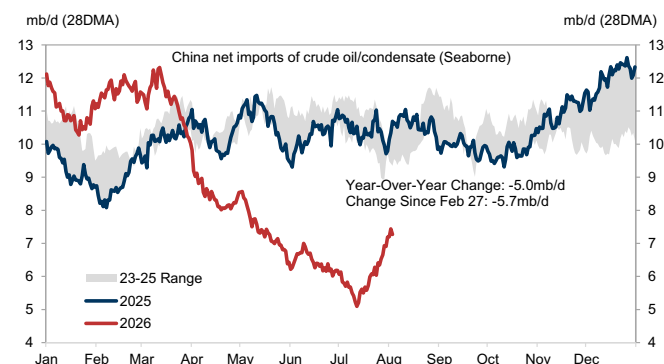


Source: Haver, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

4. In China, the divergence between strong exports and weak domestic activity grew even wider in Q2 (Exhibit 6). Export growth accelerated to 27% yoy in June, reflecting in particular higher prices (as well as increased volumes) for tech goods—over the past year, Taiwan and Korea are China's two fastest-growing markets, in part reflecting extensive regional supply chains through subsidiaries and contract manufacturers. China reported an all-time record trade surplus of \$125bn in June—\$1.5tn at an annual rate—consistent with our thesis that its global manufacturing share will continue to improve. Rapid progress in AI also creates the possibility that China could be an exporter of tech services in the future. China's trade surplus was also helped by a plunge in fossil fuel imports (Exhibit 8), reflecting a combination of substitution towards renewable energy and use of domestic inventories. This helped cushion the global energy shock, mitigating the growth hit to many of China's export markets in EM Asia.

Exhibit 7: Tech and autos driving China export growth

Source: China Customs, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 8: China's crude imports are down dramatically in 2026

Charts reference visible net imports of crude oil by sea from Kpler data.

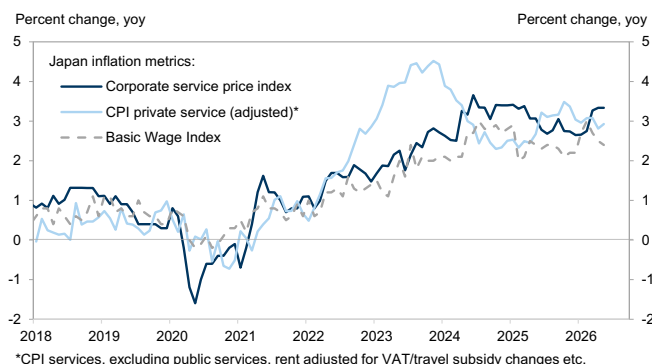
Source: Kpler, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

5. Even as exports and tech progress scale new heights, China's domestic economy remains in the doldrums. Property and infrastructure investment are down over the past year, while retail sales volumes were basically unchanged as the effect of the consumer goods trade-in program peters out. Fiscal policy tightened in Q2 as revenues outpaced spending, contributing to the deceleration in growth. Our proprietary proxy of real domestic demand growth is tracking at just 1-2% (Exhibit 6). The July Politburo meeting largely aligned with expectations, with a call to accelerate already-planned investment rather than unveiling of significant new measures. Policymakers' may be encouraged by hints that the long-awaited property market stabilization is approaching. Property prices and sales in "tier 1" cities are inching higher and the pace of decline elsewhere has slowed. Our calculation suggests the housing drag on the real economy has diminished significantly and should have largely played out by 2028, even if prices in lower-tier cities are still slipping lower.

6. In Japan, the Takaichi administration aims to run the economy hot. Fiscal policy is pushing towards a larger deficit with tax cuts and an investment push to materialize in the near future, while the real policy rate remains well in negative territory. Reflation of the economy has largely been achieved — with underlying inflation near 2%, supported by domestic wage-service price dynamics (Exhibit 9). JGB yields have reset approximately 200bp higher over the past two years (Exhibit 10), loosely comparable to the rise in inflation expectations. Markets are looking for signs of restraint on the fiscal front—with increased fiscal risk premium potentially worsening the debt-to-GDP trajectory—or any clues that the BOJ may accelerate its hiking pace (we do not expect this, and still see inflation risks skewed modestly to the downside of the BOJ's outlook). As expected, short-term intervention did not change the direction of yields or the currency; last week authorities upsized their efforts and coordinated with the US Treasury. Barring a more significant shift in macro policy, a more powerful tool at the Japanese government's disposal may be a shift in allocations by the government pension fund (GPIF) towards domestic bonds. Our strategists estimate this could generate up to \$75bn in inflows even without a change to the fund's target allocation ranges. Despite progress on reflation and corporate governance reform, a meaningful pickup in Japanese productivity growth (and with it potential GDP growth) is not yet evident. To date, the real economy continues to grow at a sub-1% yoy pace and remains

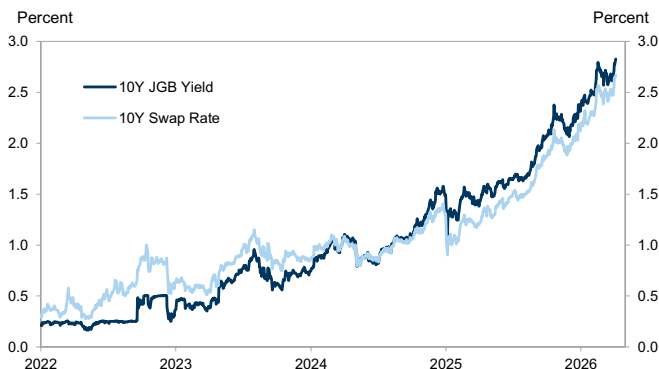
underinvested in IT as labor shortages become a constraint.

Exhibit 9: Japanese wage/service price inflation sustained



Source: Bank of Japan, MIC, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 10: Reset in JGB yields to reflect “normal” inflation, reduced BOJ role

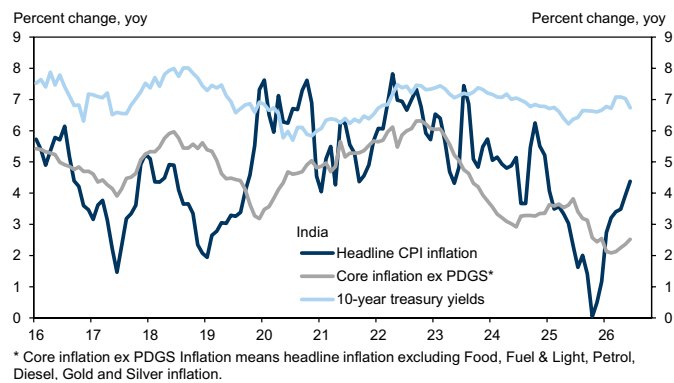


Source: BoJ, Datastream

7. Indonesia has had the worst-performing regional currency and equity market this year. High sensitivity to higher oil prices and to a stronger US dollar (given the central bank’s FX stability mandate), and lack of upside AI exposure, helps explain this. (Note that IDR, along with INR and THB—the three worst performing currencies in [Exhibit 4](#)—are not coincidentally, the three EM Asian economies in the bottom left of [Exhibit 2](#).) Given these challenges, macro performance has not been bad, with the latest GDP growth report above 5% yoy and inflation still within BI’s target band, and we have received a number of questions recently about whether the worst might be over. But policy uncertainty remains a concern for investors and rating agencies, with major shifts—such as [a plan](#) for the sovereign wealth fund Danantara to oversee natural resource exports in a bid to improve tax collection—rolled out with little or no warning. Policymakers have a range of laudable goals—higher growth, FX stability, maintenance of the 3% fiscal deficit cap, free school meals, maintaining affordable fuel prices—but they are not all jointly achievable in the short run. A clearly communicated prioritization of policies from the top, alongside an influx of technocrats with the ear of the president, could contribute to macro stability. Official communications [suggest no cabinet-level personnel changes are planned](#), but the news that Bank Indonesia governor Perry Warjiyo will step down with two years left in his second term [raises further questions](#) about the policy trajectory. We remain cautious on Indonesian assets.

8. Client interest in India may be gradually returning with greater FX stability and signs of cyclical improvement. The country has had a string of adverse shocks in recent years — a devastating Covid epidemic, then a substantial policy tightening to reduce fiscal and financial risks, then a Trump tariff broadside, and most recently the plunge in energy imports from the Middle East. In addition, reform progress has not kept pace with the country’s aspirations to capture greater global manufacturing share to “Make in India” and accelerate economic growth. Longer-term, clients worry that India is “short AI” (with risk to high-value services like IT outsourcing and GCCs), though [our analysis suggests](#) that India will also see meaningful benefits from AI rollout. For now, though there have been some [indications of a cyclical acceleration](#), our India market recommendations focus on harvesting high carry (long INR/THB, which has performed well so far) and relatively elevated longer-end yields amid rising pension saving (long 30y IGB, which is off slightly on the renewed US-Iran conflict).

Exhibit 11: Real yields remain elevated, though inflation is rising again



Source: Haver Analytics, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

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